

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Financial Advice English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For financial advisors, planners, wealth-management teams, retirement specialists, paraplanners, and client-service staff.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Standards of Conduct, Best Interest, Disclosures, and Conflicts

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Goals, Risk Profile, Asset Allocation, and IPS Language

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Retirement Planning, Income, Tax-Aware Conversations, and RMDs

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Portfolio Reviews, Volatility, Rebalancing, and Behavioral Coaching

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Products, Account Types, Rollovers, Annuities, Insurance, and Alternatives

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

07 Family, Estate, Beneficiaries, Elder Risk, and Difficult Client Moments

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Practice Management, Documentation, Complaints, Marketing, and Supervision

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A prospective client says, "I want to retire comfortably." No spending estimate, target date, or current asset summary is available.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Client objective - The goal the plan is designed to support, not necessarily the client's latest emotional reaction.

Investment objective - What the client is trying to accomplish, such as growth, income, preservation, or liquidity.

Financial plan - A coordinated view of goals, resources, assumptions, risks, and recommended actions.

Time horizon - How long the client expects to invest before needing funds for a goal.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

What would comfortable retirement include?

The lesson's prospective client has no supplied spending estimate, target retirement date, or asset summary. This is discovery-language practice, not financial advice.

01 • Financial adviser: You said you want to retire comfortably. What would comfortable mean in your everyday spending?

02 • Prospective client: I haven't worked out a spending estimate, so I can't give a reliable amount yet.

03 • Financial adviser: That's fine. We should clarify the client objective before suggesting an investment objective.

04 • Prospective client: Would picking a return target give us a useful starting point instead?

05 • Financial adviser: Not by itself. We also lack your target date and current asset summary.

06 • Prospective client: So the time horizon and resources are missing, not just the investment choice?

07 • Financial adviser: Exactly. A financial plan needs those facts and the uncertainties identified openly.

08 • Prospective client: Could we start by discussing the spending categories I need to estimate?

09 • Financial adviser: Yes. We can clarify categories and agree what information to bring, without inventing figures today.

10 • Prospective client: Then our next step is discovery, not a promise that a particular retirement outcome is achievable.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A business sale is only a possible resource

Separate fictional discovery exercise: a business owner wants to reduce working hours in three years and may sell the business; no sale valuation is available.

01 • Financial adviser: When you say reduce work in three years, do you mean fewer hours or a complete retirement?

02 • Business owner: Fewer hours initially. I might sell the business, but I don't have a valuation.

03 • Financial adviser: Then the time horizon is clearer, while the possible sale proceeds remain unknown.

04 • Business owner: Could we assume a generous sale price so the financial plan has a complete picture?

05 • Financial adviser: We can explore explicitly labeled scenarios, but we shouldn't treat an invented price as your available assets.

06 • Business owner: What clarification would help before we discuss any investment objective for those proceeds?

07 • Financial adviser: Your intended work pattern and spending needs, plus whether a sale is a goal or only an option.

08 • Business owner: The sale is an option. I don't want the plan to depend on it silently.

09 • Financial adviser: I'll keep that distinction visible and identify which information needs separate professional assessment.

10 • Business owner: Good. Let's define the objective before deciding which resources might support it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An education goal without a payment schedule

Separate fictional discovery exercise: a consultant wants to help fund a relative's education in five years, but the amount and payment pattern are unknown.

01 • Financial planner: You want to help with education in five years. Is that a single payment or several payments?

02 • Consultant: I haven't decided. I also don't know how much support I can offer.

03 • Financial planner: Then let's separate the goal's timing from the amount and payment pattern still to clarify.

04 • Consultant: Could you recommend an account immediately and work out the details afterward?

05 • Financial planner: We need the objective and constraints first. An account choice wouldn't resolve those missing facts.

06 • Consultant: The five-year time horizon is my current expectation, not a confirmed enrollment date.

07 • Financial planner: Thank you. I'll record it as an expectation so we don't make the plan more certain than you intend.

08 • Consultant: What can we usefully finish in this discovery conversation without choosing a product?

09 • Financial planner: Agree the questions about amount, timing, and your other commitments that need answers next.

10 • Consultant: That sounds right. We'll clarify the goal before treating it as a funded financial commitment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

A prospective client says, "I want to retire comfortably." No spending estimate, target date, or current asset summary is available.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

Scenario 2 | One household, two meanings of security

In a fictional discovery call, one partner means predictable monthly spending by financial security; the other means being able to change jobs. No budget or target date is supplied.

Role A: You are the financial planner. Invite both meanings and clarify what remains unknown.

Role B: You represent the household. Explain the two goals without pretending they already have a shared priority.

Possible opening: Could we separate predictable spending from flexibility to change jobs before setting one combined objective?

Success checks

- Recognize both stated goals.
- Keep spending amounts and timing unknown.
- Agree a further discovery question rather than choose a product or impose a priority.

Add a complication: One partner asks you to choose the household's priority for them.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Standards of Conduct, Best Interest, Disclosures, and Conflicts

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A client asks how a firm is paid. The adviser has the firm's current fee and relationship disclosures available.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Disclosure - Communication of relevant facts such as fees, risks, services, conflicts, and limitations.

Conflict of interest - A factor that could influence or appear to influence advice or recommendations.

Form CRS - Relationship summary designed to help retail investors understand services, fees, conflicts, and disciplinary history.

Form ADV - Investment adviser disclosure and registration form, including brochure information for clients.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Explaining the firm's compensation disclosure

Separate fictional training firm: the supplied disclosure states a \$900 annual planning fee paid by the client, no referral payments or commissions, and separately charged third-party product costs whose amounts are not supplied.

01 • Client: How is your firm paid? I would like a direct explanation of the disclosure.

02 • Financial adviser: You pay a nine-hundred-dollar annual planning fee. Under this arrangement, our firm receives no referral payments or commissions.

03 • Client: Does that mean nine hundred dollars covers every cost of implementing the plan?

04 • Financial adviser: No. Third-party product costs are separate, and we haven't established those amounts yet.

05 • Client: What is the difference between Form CRS and Form ADV in the materials?

06 • Financial adviser: Form CRS is a relationship summary covering services, fees, conflicts, and disciplinary history.

07 • Client: And Form ADV is not simply another name for that short relationship summary?

08 • Financial adviser: Correct. It is the investment adviser registration and disclosure form, including brochure information for clients.

09 • Client: So I can distinguish the planning fee from unknown product costs without assuming every conflict disappears.

10 • Financial adviser: Exactly. Disclosure explains arrangements; it does not itself eliminate a conflict or establish suitability.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A fixed planning fee and a separate product cost

Separate fictional training firm: its sample disclosure lists a \$600 one-time planning fee and says third-party product costs are separate and not quoted here.

01 • Client: The disclosure says six hundred dollars. Does that include every possible cost of implementing the plan?

02 • Financial planner: No. That is the one-time planning fee under this arrangement; third-party product costs are separate.

03 • Client: So paying for the plan and paying to hold a product are different charges?

04 • Financial planner: Exactly. The disclosure doesn't quote those product costs, so we haven't established the total yet.

05 • Client: Could the six hundred dollars be called an all-inclusive fee in our comparison?

06 • Financial planner: That would misstate the disclosure. We need the relevant additional costs before comparing totals.

07 • Client: And a clear fee explanation doesn't automatically resolve every possible conflict of interest?

08 • Financial planner: Correct. Compensation relationships and any conflicts need their own explanation, based on actual disclosures.

09 • Client: I'll describe the planning fee separately and ask for the missing implementation-cost information.

10 • Financial planner: Good. We'll clarify the full costs before discussing implementation, rather than treat the planning fee as all-inclusive.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A referral payment needs its own explanation

Separate fictional practice example: a sample disclosure states the firm receives a referral payment from one external provider; no amount is supplied.

01 • Client: The disclosure mentions a referral payment. Is that the same as a fee paid directly by me?

02 • Adviser: Not necessarily. The disclosure names the external provider as the payer, but doesn't state the amount.

03 • Client: Does that relationship create a reason to ask about a conflict of interest?

04 • Adviser: Yes. A compensation relationship can matter to how an introduction is evaluated and explained.

05 • Client: Could you reassure me that disclosure alone makes the relationship irrelevant to your judgment?

06 • Adviser: No. Explaining a relationship isn't the same as proving it has no influence or concern.

07 • Client: Then what should we clarify before I consider the introduction further?

08 • Adviser: The payment arrangement, relevant alternatives, and how the firm addresses the disclosed relationship.

09 • Client: I'll ask those questions rather than assume the provider pays nothing or that I pay everything.

10 • Adviser: Exactly. We'll use the actual disclosure and seek clarification for anything it doesn't establish.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Standards of Conduct, Best Interest, Disclosures, and Conflicts

A client asks how a firm is paid. The adviser has the firm's current fee and relationship disclosures available.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Let's walk through the current disclosures together, including fees, services, and relevant conflicts. Which parts would you like me to explain? I can also show where the information is recorded.

Scenario 2 | Service scope is not a conduct guarantee

A fictional firm's service summary lists quarterly review meetings. A prospective client interprets that schedule as proof that every recommendation will be suitable for them. No recommendation has been made.

Role A: You explain the service. Distinguish meeting frequency from the assessment of an individual recommendation.

Role B: You are the prospective client. Ask what information and disclosures would support that assessment.

Possible opening: Quarterly meetings describe the service schedule; they don't by themselves establish the appropriateness of a recommendation.

Success checks

- Explain the service-versus-assessment distinction.
- Avoid promising outcomes or asserting an unreviewed conduct standard.
- Agree to review the actual scope and relevant disclosures.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the meeting schedule a guarantee of best outcomes.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Goals, Risk Profile, Asset Allocation, and IPS Language

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A client describes themselves as comfortable with investment risk but says they need some funds for a house purchase next year.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Risk tolerance - The client's emotional willingness to accept investment volatility or loss.

Risk capacity - The client's financial ability to absorb loss without derailing goals.

Liquidity need - Need for accessible cash or investments that can be sold without unacceptable cost or delay.

IPS - Investment policy statement connecting objectives, risk, allocation, constraints, and monitoring.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Risk comfort and next year's house funds

The lesson's client feels comfortable with investment risk but needs some funds for a house purchase next year; the amount is unknown.

01 • Financial adviser: You feel comfortable with risk, but some funds are needed for a house next year. How much?

02 • Client: I haven't separated that amount from the rest of my savings yet.

03 • Financial adviser: Then we need to clarify that liquidity need before discussing a portfolio allocation.

04 • Client: Does my high risk tolerance tell you the house funds can take the same risk?

05 • Financial adviser: Not by itself. Willingness to accept fluctuations differs from the capacity to absorb losses or delayed access.

06 • Client: So the near-term purchase creates a separate question even if I'm emotionally comfortable with markets?

07 • Financial adviser: Yes. We also need to clarify how flexible the purchase timing actually is.

08 • Client: Please don't assume either the amount or the date can be changed freely.

09 • Financial adviser: I won't. We'll identify those constraints before updating an investment policy statement, or IPS.

10 • Client: Let's clarify the house commitment first, without making an investment decision from one risk label.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A questionnaire conflicts with a withdrawal need

Separate fictional review: a client selected 'no planned withdrawals' on a questionnaire but mentions an expected business payment in six months; the amount is unconfirmed.

01 • Adviser: Your questionnaire says no planned withdrawals, but you mentioned a business payment in six months.

02 • Client: I hadn't counted that because the amount isn't confirmed. Should I change the answer?

03 • Adviser: Let's clarify the obligation first and record the uncertainty instead of forcing a misleading yes-or-no response.

04 • Client: The payment is expected, but I don't yet have a reliable amount to provide.

05 • Adviser: Then the liquidity need may matter, even though its size remains unknown.

06 • Client: Would describing myself as a long-term investor make the six-month payment irrelevant?

07 • Adviser: No. Different portions of your resources may serve different time horizons and commitments.

08 • Client: I'll distinguish the expected payment from money without a planned near-term use.

09 • Adviser: Good. We'll revisit the risk-capacity assessment once the obligation is clearer.

10 • Client: And we won't turn the incomplete questionnaire into a final asset-allocation instruction today.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A loss threshold needs a meaning check

Separate fictional planning conversation: a client says they can tolerate a 10% loss, but has not specified the account, time period, or whether that means temporary fluctuation.

01 • Planner: When you say a ten-percent loss is acceptable, what account and period are you thinking about?

02 • Client: I was thinking about a temporary decline, but I hadn't specified a period.

03 • Planner: That clarification matters. A broad percentage doesn't define your complete risk tolerance or capacity.

04 • Client: Could you put ten percent in the IPS as a guaranteed maximum loss?

05 • Planner: No. Your stated comfort level isn't a guarantee that an investment can't fall further.

06 • Client: Then we should distinguish my reaction to a decline from a limit the portfolio can promise.

07 • Planner: Exactly. We also need to consider your commitments and any liquidity need during a decline.

08 • Client: Those haven't been reviewed in this conversation, so please don't infer that I can absorb any loss.

09 • Planner: I won't. We'll clarify the account, horizon, and practical consequences before recording a fuller profile.

10 • Client: That gives the percentage context instead of letting it stand in for the whole assessment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Goals, Risk Profile, Asset Allocation, and IPS Language

A client describes themselves as comfortable with investment risk but says they need some funds for a house purchase next year.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: When you say you're comfortable with risk, are you including the money needed next year? Let's distinguish your willingness to accept losses from your ability to absorb them for each goal.

Scenario 2 | Two accounts with different purposes

A fictional client has one account earmarked for an expense in eighteen months and another described as long-term savings. Amounts and investment holdings are not supplied.

Role A: You are the adviser. Ask how fixed the expense is and distinguish the accounts' purposes.

Role B: You are the client. Explain that one general risk label may not describe both accounts.

Possible opening: Could we assess the eighteen-month expense separately from the savings with a longer horizon?

Success checks

- Identify the two different horizons.
- Ask about the fixed or flexible nature of the expense.
- Avoid choosing allocations from incomplete facts.

Add a complication: The client asks you to assign the same allocation to both before discussing amounts.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Retirement Planning, Income, Tax-Aware Conversations, and RMDs

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A retirement illustration assumes a fixed annual return. A client reads the chart as a promise of future income.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Retirement income - Cash flow used to support spending after work income decreases or stops.

Withdrawal rate - Percentage of a portfolio withdrawn over a period, often discussed in retirement income planning.

Sequence risk - Risk that early losses during withdrawals harm long-term sustainability.

Monte Carlo analysis - Simulation showing possible goal outcomes under many market paths, not a guarantee.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The smooth retirement line is not a promise

The lesson's illustration assumes a fixed annual return, and the client reads the result as promised income.

01 • Client: The retirement chart rises smoothly. Does that mean my future income is guaranteed?

02 • Financial planner: No. The illustration assumes a fixed annual return; actual investment returns need not follow that path.

03 • Client: Then what part of this chart is an observation about my actual future?

04 • Financial planner: None of the future path is observed. It is a modeled result under stated assumptions.

05 • Client: Would changing the withdrawal rate alter the retirement-income illustration as well?

06 • Financial planner: Yes. That is another assumption to examine, not a number that creates a guaranteed outcome.

07 • Client: And sequence risk concerns the order in which returns occur while money is withdrawn?

08 • Financial planner: Yes. A smooth fixed-return illustration doesn't show every effect of a different return sequence.

09 • Client: Please describe the chart as conditional and show which assumptions need further discussion.

10 • Financial planner: I will. We can review uncertainty without treating this language exercise as an income recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A simulation percentage needs a definition

Separate fictional retirement exercise: a Monte Carlo output labels 80% of modeled paths successful under specified assumptions; success criteria have not been explained to the client.

01 • Client: The Monte Carlo analysis says eighty percent successful. Does that give me an eighty-percent personal guarantee?

02 • Planner: No. It summarizes modeled paths under the chosen assumptions and a defined success test.

03 • Client: What does successful mean in this particular model? I haven't seen that definition.

04 • Planner: We need to explain it before interpreting the percentage. The label alone isn't enough.

05 • Client: Could changing the spending assumption change how many paths pass the test?

06 • Planner: Yes. Inputs and model design affect the output, so the result needs that context.

07 • Client: Then the percentage isn't an observed frequency for my own future retirement.

08 • Planner: Correct. It's a conditional model result, with limitations that should stay visible.

09 • Client: Let's review the success definition and assumptions before discussing any plan changes.

10 • Planner: Agreed. We won't translate the simulation label into a promise of future income.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A distribution question needs current individual review

Separate fictional planning call: a client asks whether a retirement-account distribution is required; account type, age, and current applicable rules have not been checked.

01 • Client: A friend mentioned required minimum distributions. Must I take money out of my account this year?

02 • Financial adviser: We haven't checked your account type, relevant personal facts, or the current applicable requirements.

03 • Client: Could you use my friend's situation as a quick answer for mine?

04 • Financial adviser: No. Their circumstances don't establish yours, and we shouldn't invent a deadline or distribution amount.

05 • Client: So this is a question requiring verification, not another assumption for the income chart.

06 • Financial adviser: Exactly. We can identify the information needed and involve the appropriate account and tax professionals.

07 • Client: Should I treat any illustration we've discussed as tax advice about the distribution?

08 • Financial adviser: No. A retirement-income illustration doesn't resolve your individual tax or distribution obligations.

09 • Client: I'll provide the account details through the proper channel for review.

10 • Financial adviser: Then we'll confirm the appropriate source of guidance before describing any required action.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Retirement Planning, Income, Tax-Aware Conversations, and RMDs

A retirement illustration assumes a fixed annual return. A client reads the chart as a promise of future income.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: This is an illustration based on assumptions, not a guaranteed income path. Let's review how different returns and spending needs change the picture before discussing any planning decision.

Scenario 2 | Inflation is absent from the headline

A fictional retirement illustration shows level annual spending in nominal dollars. The headline calls the spending power constant, but no inflation adjustment is included.

Role A: You are the planner. Explain the difference between unchanged dollar spending and unchanged purchasing power.

Role B: You are the client. Ask which assumption the illustration makes without supplying an inflation forecast.

Possible opening: The dollar amount stays level here, but that does not establish constant purchasing power.

Success checks

- Distinguish nominal dollars from purchasing power.
- Identify the missing inflation treatment.
- Agree to label and review assumptions rather than promise future spending power.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to insert an inflation number without labeling it as an assumption.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Portfolio Reviews, Volatility, Rebalancing, and Behavioral Coaching

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A client's statement shows a decline, and they want to know whether the change reflects withdrawals, fees, or market movement.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Benchmark - Reference index or blend used to evaluate portfolio performance.

Drawdown - Decline from a prior high value to a lower value.

Rebalancing - Adjusting portfolio back toward target allocation after movement or client change.

Asset allocation - Division of portfolio among asset categories such as equities, fixed income, cash, and alternatives.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A lower balance has several possible components

The lesson's client sees a statement decline and asks whether withdrawals, fees, or market movement explain it; amounts are not supplied.

01 • Client: My statement balance declined. Can you tell whether withdrawals, fees, or markets caused the change?

02 • Portfolio adviser: We need to reconcile those components rather than call the whole decline an investment loss.

03 • Client: Is a balance change different from the portfolio return shown against a benchmark?

04 • Portfolio adviser: Yes. Cash entering or leaving an account changes the balance without being investment performance itself.

05 • Client: Then should we examine the cash-flow and fee entries before discussing market movement?

06 • Portfolio adviser: Exactly. We don't have the amounts here, so I won't invent the breakdown.

07 • Client: Would the decline alone justify a rebalancing instruction today?

08 • Portfolio adviser: Not from this information. Rebalancing concerns the asset allocation and requires its own review.

09 • Client: Let's explain the statement first, then discuss any implications separately.

10 • Portfolio adviser: Agreed. I'll reconcile the entries and distinguish confirmed components from any unanswered performance question.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Rebalancing is not restoring a previous balance

Separate fictional review: a portfolio's asset weights have drifted from its stated targets; the client thinks rebalancing guarantees recovery of a previous balance.

01 • Client: If we rebalance, will the account return to its previous dollar balance?

02 • Adviser: No. Rebalancing concerns adjusting asset weights toward agreed targets, not guaranteeing a particular account value.

03 • Client: So a target allocation and a target balance describe different things?

04 • Adviser: Exactly. The weights describe the portfolio's composition; the balance depends on values and cash flows.

05 • Client: We know the weights drifted, but have we established that a trade is appropriate now?

06 • Adviser: Not in this conversation. The current circumstances, costs, and relevant consequences still need review.

07 • Client: Then please explain the drift without turning the explanation into a trade instruction.

08 • Adviser: I will. We can compare actual and target weights while keeping any action undecided.

09 • Client: That helps me understand the term without expecting it to reverse a drawdown.

10 • Adviser: Good. We'll discuss the review findings before making any separate decision about changes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A drawdown and a period return use different starting points

Separate fictional training chart: an account value peaked before the reporting period began; the chart labels both drawdown and period return without explaining their bases.

01 • Client: The chart shows two different declines. Are the drawdown and period return contradicting each other?

02 • Performance adviser: They may use different starting points. We need to inspect the calculation labels.

03 • Client: The peak occurred before this reporting period began. Does that explain why the comparison matters?

04 • Performance adviser: Yes. Drawdown can reference a prior peak, whereas period return starts from the specified reporting period.

05 • Client: Then neither number should be relabeled as the other just to simplify the conversation.

06 • Performance adviser: Correct. Cash-flow treatment and the exact definitions also need to be clear.

07 • Client: Could we compare either figure with a benchmark without checking the same basis?

08 • Performance adviser: That wouldn't be a reliable comparison. We should align the period and method first.

09 • Client: Please explain both starting points before drawing conclusions about the portfolio.

10 • Performance adviser: I will, and we'll keep any investment action separate from interpreting the chart.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Portfolio Reviews, Volatility, Rebalancing, and Behavioral Coaching

A client's statement shows a decline, and they want to know whether the change reflects withdrawals, fees, or market movement.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Let's separate the withdrawals, fees, and investment movement for the same period. That will explain the balance change more clearly than looking only at the opening and closing totals.

Scenario 2 | A contribution makes the balance look stronger

A fictional account's balance rose during a month when the client added money. No investment-return calculation is supplied, and the client wants to compare the balance increase with a benchmark return.

Role A: You are the adviser. Explain the contribution-versus-performance distinction.

Role B: You are the client. Ask what comparable calculation is needed before claiming outperformance.

Possible opening: The contribution increased your balance, but it isn't itself an investment return.

Success checks

- Keep contributions visible.
- Do not invent the actual investment return.
- Agree a like-for-like performance comparison before interpreting success.

Add a complication: A colleague proposes excluding the contribution from the explanation because the result looks positive.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Products, Account Types, Rollovers, Annuities, Insurance, and Alternatives

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A client is comparing two account options. One summary omits exit charges and ongoing service differences.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Expense ratio - Annual fund operating costs expressed as a percentage of assets.

Surrender charge - Fee for withdrawing from certain products during a specified period.

Managed account - Account in which investments are managed for the client under an agreed program or mandate.

Annuity - Insurance contract that may provide income or guarantees with costs, restrictions, and conditions.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Compare this wording: This option is more better.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - B. An increase of one percentage point.
 - C. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two accounts with incomplete exit-cost information

The lesson's account comparison omits exit charges and ongoing service differences from one summary; no product choice is authorized.

01 • Client: This account summary looks cheaper. Should we choose it over the other option?

02 • Adviser: The comparison omits exit charges and ongoing service differences from one summary, so it isn't complete.

03 • Client: Would comparing only the stated expense ratio still answer the total-cost question?

04 • Adviser: No. That measure may cover only part of the costs relevant to the comparison.

05 • Client: Then we need the same holding period and exit assumptions for both options.

06 • Adviser: Yes, along with the services actually included. We shouldn't assume an omitted charge is zero.

07 • Client: Does a managed-account label guarantee that both options provide identical ongoing support?

08 • Adviser: No. We need their actual service descriptions rather than infer scope from a label.

09 • Client: I'll ask for the missing information before treating the lower headline as better value.

10 • Adviser: Good. We'll compare the tradeoffs on a consistent basis without selecting an account from incomplete facts.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Lower annual cost or more frequent reviews?

Separate fictional comparison for one year: option A lists a \$500 annual service cost and one annual review; B lists \$800 and quarterly reviews. Review scope, product costs, exit charges, and individual suitability are unassessed.

01 • Client: Option A costs five hundred dollars for the year; B costs eight hundred. What service difference is known?

02 • Adviser: A includes one annual review, whereas B includes quarterly reviews, four during the same year.

03 • Client: So B costs three hundred dollars more for three additional scheduled reviews on this comparison.

04 • Adviser: Yes. A has the lower stated annual service cost, while B provides more frequent scheduled reviews.

05 • Client: That is a real tradeoff, but does more frequent automatically mean more useful for me?

06 • Adviser: No. The review scope and your needs require assessment; frequency alone does not establish suitability.

07 • Client: And neither quoted service cost establishes the complete amount I might pay for the account.

08 • Adviser: Correct. Product costs and any exit charges remain unassessed, so neither is a complete total.

09 • Client: I would like to examine review scope before choosing between lower cost and greater frequency.

10 • Adviser: Agreed. Those known differences guide our questions without deciding the account choice from incomplete facts.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A rollover comparison needs the existing account too

Separate fictional review: a proposed rollover account has a detailed service brochure, but the existing account's costs and features have not been gathered.

01 • Client: The proposed account brochure is detailed. Can we compare it with my existing arrangement now?

02 • Adviser: We can identify its stated features, but we lack the existing account's costs and services.

03 • Client: Could we assume the old arrangement has fewer services because its brochure isn't here?

04 • Adviser: No. Missing information doesn't establish a disadvantage, just an incomplete comparison.

05 • Client: Then the same criteria should cover ongoing costs, available features, and any exit consequences.

06 • Adviser: Yes, including relevant differences that may matter to your circumstances, without assuming the rollover is preferable.

07 • Client: Would discussing the comparison itself authorize moving the account?

08 • Adviser: No. This is information gathering, not an instruction or completed individual recommendation.

09 • Client: I'll obtain the existing documents and leave the transfer question open.

10 • Adviser: Then we can explain the real tradeoffs rather than compare a full brochure with an information gap.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Products, Account Types, Rollovers, Annuities, Insurance, and Alternatives

A client is comparing two account options. One summary omits exit charges and ongoing service differences.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: We need the same categories for both options: charges, services, restrictions, and relevant tax considerations. I'll use the current documents to build a comparable summary before we discuss suitability.

Scenario 2 | Different service frequencies in a cost table

In a fictional comparison, option A includes an annual review and option B quarterly reviews. Their quoted costs cover the same year, but the review scope and other charges are unknown.

Role A: You explain the comparison. Identify the service-frequency difference and missing scope.

Role B: You are the client. Ask whether more meetings necessarily mean more useful service for your needs.

Possible opening: The costs cover the same year, but the review frequency differs and the review scope is still unclear.

Success checks

- Name annual versus quarterly frequency.
- Keep service quality, scope, and other charges unestablished.
- Agree to compare relevant services rather than rank by frequency alone.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call quarterly reviews automatically superior.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Family, Estate, Beneficiaries, Elder Risk, and Difficult Client Moments

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A client asks how to review beneficiary details after a family change. The service team can explain the firm's process but cannot resolve legal questions.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Beneficiary designation - Account instruction naming who receives assets after death, subject to account and legal rules.

Refer - Direct the client to another qualified professional for tax, legal, insurance, or specialized advice.

Document - Record facts, rationale, alternatives, risks, client instructions, and follow-up.

Escalate - Raise an issue to compliance, supervision, legal, tax, or specialist support.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - B. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - C. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - B. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - C. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Requesting a beneficiary review after a family change

The lesson's client wants to review beneficiary details. The service team can explain its process but cannot resolve legal questions.

01 • Client: After a family change, I'd like to review the beneficiary details on my account.

02 • Client service specialist: We can explain the firm's review process. Which account would you like us to locate?

03 • Client: I'll identify it through the secure channel. Can you tell me what the family change legally requires?

04 • Client service specialist: That legal question needs the appropriate qualified professional; I can't resolve it through account servicing.

05 • Client: Then please arrange the account review and tell me which process information I should provide.

06 • Client service specialist: I will. We'll distinguish reviewing the beneficiary designation from completing an authorized change.

07 • Client: Could you document that I requested a review, without recording a change I haven't instructed?

08 • Client service specialist: Yes. I'll keep that scope clear and refer the legal question appropriately.

09 • Client: Please confirm the next step and realistic timing once you've checked the account process.

10 • Client service specialist: Agreed. No completed update or legal outcome will be implied by this request.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A relative requests access to account details

Separate fictional service call: a client's adult relative asks for account information; their authorization has not been verified.

01 • Client's relative: Could you send me the account details so I can help my parent prepare for a meeting?

02 • Service specialist: Before discussing account information, we need to verify the relevant authorization through the firm's process.

03 • Client's relative: I'm a family member. Doesn't that settle who can receive the information?

04 • Service specialist: The relationship alone doesn't establish the authorization in our record. I shouldn't assume it.

05 • Client's relative: Then please tell me how to request the check without sharing private details now.

06 • Service specialist: I can explain the approved verification route and refer any legal-authority questions for qualified review.

07 • Client's relative: Will you document this as my parent's instruction to disclose the account?

08 • Service specialist: No. I'll record your inquiry accurately, not attribute an instruction we haven't received or verified.

09 • Client's relative: Please arrange the process explanation, and I'll avoid asking you to bypass the check.

10 • Service specialist: Thank you. We'll confirm the appropriate next step without disclosing unverified account information.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Escalating a concern without diagnosing incapacity

Separate fictional service exercise: a client repeats the same payment question during a call. The cause is unknown, and no change is authorized.

01 • Service associate: Could you review this call concern? The client repeated the same payment question several times.

02 • Service supervisor: What did you observe directly, and what are you asking us to assess?

03 • Service associate: Only the repeated question. I don't know the cause and haven't made a capacity judgment.

04 • Service supervisor: Good. Document the observable interaction without diagnosing the client or assigning a family motive.

05 • Service associate: Please advise on the appropriate follow-up under our service process before any action changes.

06 • Service supervisor: I'll review the concern. Did the conversation establish an instruction to change a payment?

07 • Service associate: No. No change was authorized, and I won't treat the repeated question as an instruction.

08 • Service supervisor: Then keep that boundary explicit while we assess what clarification or escalation is appropriate.

09 • Service associate: I'll provide the relevant record through the restricted channel and request a confirmed next step.

10 • Service supervisor: I'll take the review and avoid turning an observation into an unsupported conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Family, Estate, Beneficiaries, Elder Risk, and Difficult Client Moments

A client asks how to review beneficiary details after a family change. The service team can explain the firm's process but cannot resolve legal questions.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: We can help you review the beneficiary information held by the firm and explain the update process. For questions about legal effects or estate planning, let's identify the appropriate qualified adviser.

Scenario 2 | A beneficiary form received but not checked

A fictional client submitted a beneficiary form and asks whether the account now reflects it. The service team confirms receipt only; completeness and processing have not been checked.

Role A: You are the service specialist. Request the processing-status check and explain the current limit.

Role B: You are the client. Ask for confirmation of the actual record without assuming receipt equals completion.

Possible opening: We have received the form, but I need to confirm review and processing before describing the account as updated.

Success checks

- Separate receipt from completed processing.
- Request a precise account-status check.
- Refer legal-effect questions rather than invent an answer.

Add a complication: The client asks you to confirm the legal effect of the form before review.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Practice Management, Documentation, Complaints, Marketing, and Supervision

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A client says a service email did not answer their complaint. The record shows an acknowledgment but no response to the specific concern.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Disclosure - Communication of relevant facts such as fees, risks, services, conflicts, and limitations.

Document - Record facts, rationale, alternatives, risks, client instructions, and follow-up.

Supervise - Review and oversee advice, communication, accounts, and advisor activity under firm policy.

Update - Refresh client information, risk profile, beneficiary details, or planning assumptions.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
 - B. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - C. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.
 - B. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - C. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Acknowledgment did not answer the complaint

The lesson's complaint record contains an acknowledgment but no response to the client's specific concern.

01 • Client: Your service email acknowledged my complaint, but it didn't answer the concern I raised.

02 • Service manager: You're right. The record shows receipt was acknowledged, not that your specific concern was addressed.

03 • Client: Then why was the email described as our response rather than an acknowledgment?

04 • Service manager: That wording was misleading. I'll correct the status and keep the substantive response open.

05 • Client: Can you promise the complaint is resolved now that we've discussed the mistake?

06 • Service manager: No. Correcting the communication doesn't resolve the underlying issue or determine its outcome.

07 • Client: Please document the unanswered concern and tell me who will review it.

08 • Service manager: I'll route it to the responsible reviewer and confirm the next update after checking the process.

09 • Client: I'd rather receive accurate status than an invented deadline or a premature closure.

10 • Service manager: Understood. The correction is acknowledgment received, substantive response still pending, and review to be confirmed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A review meeting listed as completed by mistake

Separate fictional practice record: a client meeting was scheduled but did not occur; an internal status incorrectly marks the review completed.

01 • Client service associate: The record marks the portfolio review complete, but the scheduled meeting didn't take place.

02 • Supervising adviser: Then we need to correct the record, not imply advice was delivered during a meeting that never occurred.

03 • Client service associate: Should I replace the status without retaining any explanation of the correction?

04 • Supervising adviser: Use the appropriate record process and document why the original status was inaccurate.

05 • Client service associate: The corrected description is scheduled meeting not held, with the review still pending.

06 • Supervising adviser: Yes. Also check whether the client received a message based on the incorrect completion status.

07 • Client service associate: That hasn't been checked, so I won't claim a misleading message was actually sent.

08 • Supervising adviser: Good. Review distribution separately and correct any affected communication that is confirmed.

09 • Client service associate: I'll request a new meeting time without calling it a follow-up to completed advice.

10 • Supervising adviser: Then confirm the corrected status and keep unperformed work visible for supervision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A service promise exceeds the approved description

Separate fictional practice example: a draft client message promises monthly reviews, while the supplied service description lists quarterly reviews. The message is unsent.

01 • Marketing coordinator: My draft promises monthly reviews, but the service description says quarterly. It hasn't been sent.

02 • Supervising adviser: Please correct it before distribution. We shouldn't create an unsupported service promise through marketing wording.

03 • Marketing coordinator: Could we say frequent reviews instead and leave the actual frequency unclear?

04 • Supervising adviser: That avoids the error only superficially. Use the supplied quarterly description accurately.

05 • Marketing coordinator: The corrected sentence will say that the described service includes quarterly review meetings.

06 • Supervising adviser: Good. Keep any other scope claims tied to the actual service materials and disclosures.

07 • Marketing coordinator: Should we apologize to clients for receiving the monthly promise?

08 • Supervising adviser: No distribution occurred in this case. Document the draft correction without inventing a client-facing incident.

09 • Marketing coordinator: I'll submit the corrected draft for review and keep its publication status unsent.

10 • Supervising adviser: Then supervision can confirm the wording before any communication creates an expectation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Practice Management, Documentation, Complaints, Marketing, and Supervision

A client says a service email did not answer their complaint. The record shows an acknowledgment but no response to the specific concern.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: You're right that our earlier message did not address that concern. I'll record the issue accurately and confirm the next step in our complaints process, including when you should expect an update.

Scenario 2 | A complaint category misses the issue

A fictional client complained about a delayed callback. The record categorizes it as a fee question, and no callback review has occurred. The client points out the mismatch.

Role A: You are the service manager. Acknowledge the misclassification and state the actual concern.

Role B: You are the client. Ask how the callback issue will receive review without accepting a premature resolution claim.

Possible opening: We recorded your callback concern as a fee question; that was inaccurate and needs correction.

Success checks

- Name and correct the category mismatch.
- Separate record correction from substantive review.
- Agree review ownership and an accurate next-status update.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests closing the complaint after changing its category.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Standards of Conduct, Best Interest, Disclosures, and Conflicts

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: Let's walk through the current disclosures together, including fees, services, and relevant conflicts. Which parts would you like me to explain? I can also show where the information is recorded.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Goals, Risk Profile, Asset Allocation, and IPS Language

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: When you say you're comfortable with risk, are you including the money needed next year? Let's distinguish your willingness to accept losses from your ability to absorb them for each goal.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Retirement Planning, Income, Tax-Aware Conversations, and RMDs

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: This is an illustration based on assumptions, not a guaranteed income path. Let's review how different returns and spending needs change the picture before discussing any planning decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Portfolio Reviews, Volatility, Rebalancing, and Behavioral Coaching

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: Let's separate the withdrawals, fees, and investment movement for the same period. That will explain the balance change more clearly than looking only at the opening and closing totals.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Products, Account Types, Rollovers, Annuities, Insurance, and Alternatives

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

B: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

C: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

Check 2: B - An increase of one percentage point.

A: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

B: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

C: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

Model response: We need the same categories for both options: charges, services, restrictions, and relevant tax considerations. I'll use the current documents to build a comparable summary before we discuss suitability.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Family, Estate, Beneficiaries, Elder Risk, and Difficult Client Moments

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: B - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

B: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

C: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

Check 2: A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: The requested action and information are explicit.

B: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

C: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

Model response: We can help you review the beneficiary information held by the firm and explain the update process. For questions about legal effects or estate planning, let's identify the appropriate qualified adviser.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Practice Management, Documentation, Complaints, Marketing, and Supervision

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

B: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

C: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

Check 2: C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: The reader still lacks the information they need.

B: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

C: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

Model response: You're right that our earlier message did not address that concern. I'll record the issue accurately and confirm the next step in our complaints process, including when you should expect an update.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Financial Advice English

Professional audience: financial advisors, planners, wealth-management teams, retirement specialists, paraplanners, and client-service staff

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

Original fictional case: A prospective client says, "I want to retire comfortably." No spending estimate, target date, or current asset summary is available.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Client objective: The goal the plan is designed to support, not necessarily the client's latest emotional reaction. / Investment objective: What the client is trying to accomplish, such as growth, income, preservation, or liquidity. / Financial plan: A coordinated view of goals, resources, assumptions, risks, and recommended actions. / Time horizon: How long the client expects to invest before needing funds for a goal.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level